Abstract

Modern Chinese Demonstrative *gāi*: A Corpus-based Linguistic Investigation

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This thesis investigates the use of demonstrative 该 *gāi* in modern Mandarin Chinese based on data from corpora constructed by Beijing Language and Culture University Corpus Center (BLCU Corpus Center, BCC). The main findings are as follows: 1) *gāi* prefers monosyllabic nouns; 2) *gāi* favors nouns referring to institutions, locations, and objects, but it is rarely used before temporal nouns; 3) *gāi* does not allow preceding pronouns and tends to leave out singular classifiers; 4) the genitive marker de is usually omitted when *gāi* + noun modifies another noun. Further by contrasting it with similar relevant demonstratives, this thesis proposes a multidimensional description of *gāi*'s use which integrates three contextual factors. Regarding the referent, *gāi* has a strong preference for institutional and locational nouns, especially administrative division names. Regarding the participant, *gāi* is used when referring to a referent in which neither the speaker nor the addressee is involved. In this sense, it is in complementary distribution with 本 *běn* (referents involving the speaker) and 贵 *guì* (referents involving the addressee). Regarding the linguistic distance (*yǔjù* 语距, see Feng, 2018), it is a formal stylistic-register demonstrative and possibly the proximal counterpart of 此 *cǐ*. The findings can serve different practical purposes, such as dictionary editing, textbook compiling, and language learning and teaching. Meanwhile, it contributes to the work on the Chinese demonstrative system and demonstratives across languages more generally.